Uttar Pradesh...

THE LAND OF TIRTHANKARS

Can you guess where the largest sculpture collection in the world related to Jain culture is located. It is neither in Rajasthan nor in Bihar but in a lesser-known part of Uttar Pradesh where stands the fort complex consisting 31 Jain temples housing around 2,000 sculptures which is in fact the largest such collection in the world. It's the District Lalitpur in the land of Bundelkhand which is considered the most important Jain religious site in Uttar Pradesh and thousands of tourists visit this place every year.

It is not the only place but one out of many important religious places related to Jain Culture which is being developed by the Uttar Pradesh government under Jain Circuit. In Varanasi, a lot of development work on sites related to Jain heritage is going on under the PPP model also.

The Ministry of Tourism under the Swadesh Darshan Scheme has identified Tirthankar Circuit as one of the fifteen thematic circuits for development in the country. All the sites associated with Jainism are covered under this circuit. Considering that 17 out of 24 tirthankars of Jainism were born in what is now Uttar Pradesh, there is a lot of scope for developing a tourist circuit in the state.

The development of tirthankar circuit in UP will further promote religious tourism in the state. It will help in spreading the messages of peace.

The Uttar Pradesh government last year announced its new tourism policy. Many circuits focusing on the development of sites related to different themes and religious beliefs were proposed and work has been started on them also. State government under the leadership of Yogi Adityananth has decided to develop the religious sites related to Jainism under the Jain circuit. The government through the policy has also laid emphasis on developing the lesser-known places.

Lalitpur is a very important part of Jain heritage. The Jain circuit will also be extended from Deogarh, Hastinapur to Parshwanath Digambar Jain temple, Ramnagar.

State cabinet has also paved the way for the setting up of Mahavir University in Meerut.

UP is a sacred destination for Jains as 17 tirthankaras were born here in Meerut, Agra, Kaushambi, Varanasi, Deoria, Ayodhaya, Shravasti and Farrukhabad.

Some of the Jain culture destinations are situated in remote areas and lack basic facilities, That is why the state government decided to work on the development of these places under the Jain circuit.

The vast land of Uttar Pradesh is richly blessed by the Jain pilgrimages. Not to mention this state in North India has also been the birthplace of six Jain Tirthankaras, namely Rishabhanatha, Ajitanatha, Abhinandananatha, Sumatinatha, Anantanatha, and Parshvanatha. While the first five graced the land of Ayodhya with their birth, Varanasi was blessed by being the birthplace of Parshvanatha, the 23rd Jain Tirthankara. Needless to say, Uttar Pradesh has an ancient connection with Jainism.

The influence of Jainism can be seen largely in the Bundelkhand region of Uttar Pradesh where Deogarh is an important Jain pilgrimage destination with the Fort Temples dominating its silhouette.

